PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Isuzu Trooper (second generation)

1991–2002 · UBS25 · UBS26 · Acura SLX · Monterey

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Check the oil on any 3.5 (1998–2002)**
  Pull the dipstick before anything else and ask how much oil it uses. NHTSA's complaint files describe 6VE1s using a quart every 450–1,000 miles and several that ran dry and seized without an oil-light warning. A truck with a documented engine rebuild or replacement can be the better buy.
- [ ] **Inspect the 4L30-E automatic**
  One long-time owner on Bob Is The Oil Guy says most failures of these gearboxes come from running low on fluid, and that they're very sensitive to fill level. Look for leaks at the accumulator cover and drain bolt, check the fluid, and make sure every gear engages cleanly hot and cold.
- [ ] **Test the Torque On Demand system (1998+)**
  A flashing TOD light and shudder usually point to the transfer-case or driveshaft speed sensors, according to Edmunds forum owners. One was quoted about $700 for the pair. Test 4WD Auto, 4H and 4L on loose ground.
- [ ] **Listen for stalling at stops**
  Many 1998–2000 owners told NHTSA about stalling when slowing or turning, and about upper and lower intake manifold gaskets replaced more than once. Edmunds owners call the 3.5's intake gasket a common fault.
- [ ] **Ask for the timing-belt and water-pump receipt**
  Both V6s have belt-driven cams. Owners on Edmunds plan the belt, water pump and spark plugs around 75,000 miles, and one on Bob Is The Oil Guy says the belt is good for about 100,000 miles. With no records, do it now and confirm the interval in the manual.
- [ ] **Make sure the 4WD actually engages**
  Bob Is The Oil Guy owners say the front-axle 4WD actuator is known to seize in rust-prone areas. Lock it in, drive on gravel and listen for the front axle pulling.
- [ ] **Check that the recalls were done**
  Accelerator cables that can stick on 1992–95 trucks (04V199), cam seal end plugs that can blow out and leak oil on 1992–94 trucks (94V132), loose transfer-case flange nuts on 1998s (98V180) and fuel-line separation in frontal crashes on 2000–01 TOD trucks (00V253, 00V376).
- [ ] **Look underneath for rust**
  Bob Is The Oil Guy owners rate Trooper rust as similar to other Japanese trucks of the era, but rust-belt trucks do die of it. One 1996 owner's NHTSA complaint describes chassis corrosion. Check the frame rails, rear suspension mounts and the rear doors.

YEARS TO KNOW

1998–2000	BEWARE	Peak years for NHTSA complaints about 3.5 oil consumption, engines running dry and stalling: by our keyword count, about 38 of the 81 complaints for 1999 describe heavy oil

use or seizure. CarComplaints rates 2000 as the worst Trooper year, mainly for transmission failures. Check any 3.5 carefully

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Accelerator cable can stick**
  1992–1995 · NHTSA 04V199
- ☐ **Camshaft seal end plug can dislodge**
  1992–1994 · NHTSA 94V132
- ☐ **Rear center seat-belt buckle**
  1996 · NHTSA 96V248
- ☐ **Front hub missing lock washer or screws**
  1997 · NHTSA 97V035
- ☐ **Left front brake line clearance**
  1996–1997 · NHTSA 97V092
- ☐ **Transfer case flange nuts**
  1998 · NHTSA 98V180
- ☐ **TOD trucks: fuel leak in a frontal crash**
  2000–2001 · NHTSA 00V253 / 00V376

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Chassis codes**
  UBS25 = 3.2 L 6VD1 V6, UBS26 = 3.5 L 6VE1 V6, UBS69 = 3.1 L 4JG2 turbo-diesel, UBS73 = 3.0 L 4JX1 turbo-diesel. Japanese model codes add a prefix and suffix, for example E-UBS25GW or KD-UBS69GW.
- ☐ **3.2 or 3.5**
  1992–97 US trucks have the 3.2 (SOHC on the S, DOHC on the 1992–95 LS); 1998–2002 trucks have the 3.5 DOHC. The 1998 facelift, with new lamps and fenders and a body-colored hard spare cover, is the easy visual tell.
- ☐ **Torque On Demand**
  TOD trucks (1998 on, S Performance and S Luxury at first) have a '4WD Auto' mode and a TOD indicator. Part-time trucks don't.
- ☐ **Acura SLX**
  Sold for the 1996–99 model years, automatic only, with the 3.2 and then (from 1998) the 3.5 and TOD. Mechanically a Trooper with Acura trim.
- ☐ **Re-badges and imports**
  Holden Jackaroo and Monterey, Opel and Vauxhall Monterey, Honda Horizon, Subaru Bighorn, Chevrolet Trooper and HSV Jackaroo are all UBS. Diesels and right-hand drive mean an import.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/trooper/trooper-2/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks